

Banner Advertising Effectiveness: An Experimental Study

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Banner advertising is the most popular form of advertising in the internet, which promotes products and services in websites. Banner is a graphic image that is designed to catch the attention of the targeted audience. Banner advertisements are embedded into web pages and when an internet user visits a particular website this ad is presented virtually as the web page loads. Banner advertising is used to a) increase website traffic, b) enhance product sales, c) inform targeted audiences of new product and services or sales and discounts and d) create brand awareness. For companies banner advertising is cost-effective promotes company's image, generates sales leads and provides the opportunity to trace or track its effectiveness. Moreover, banner advertising can engage a target group with the company by using attractive designs (colors, graphics, logos and texts). Due to its importance, banner advertising has attracted significant research attention. Studies have attempted to explain its effectiveness as expressed by website visits, advertising attitudes, purchase intentions and actual internet purchase behavior. Others have examined the elements that make this tool more efficient and attractive such as consumer characteristics, interactivity, exposure frequency, embedded content and design elements. In line with previous research, the scope of our study is to evaluate the effectiveness of banner advertising by investigating the role of product type and content elements. Specifically we examine the effect of congruity (between the advertising copy and the image of the advertised product) and the type of advertising copy. In order to achieve the objectives of our study we conducted two experiments with a 2(congruency: congruent, incongruent) x 2(type of advertising copy: emotional, informational) x 3(product involvement: low, medium and high) design. Experiment 1 was run with three unknown brands and experiment 2 with three well known brands. Overall 30 people participated in the first experiment and 20 in the second. In the first experiment, a two-way analysis of variance (ANOVAs) indicated no statistically significant interaction between congruency and advertising copy type on attitude toward the ad ($F=.021$, $p<.885$). On the contrary, in the second experiment, the interaction between the two variables was significant ($F=6.757$, $p<.012$). It appears that a congruent emotional copy ($M=3.53$) leads to more positive attitude toward the ad than an incongruent emotional copy ($M=2.60$), while an incongruent informational copy ($M=3.40$) results in more positive attitude toward the ad than a congruent

informational copy (3.07). The level of involvement exerts no effect on the interaction between the two variables (experiment 1: $F=1.321$, $p<.273$ and experiment 2: $F=.018$, $p<.982$). The managerial and theoretical implications of the study are discussed and compared with earlier work on banner advertising effectiveness.